

CHEERED TO THE FLAG

Henri Farman made aviation history when he won the Grand Prix d'Aviation by completing the first $\frac{3}{4}$ -mile (1-km) circular flight in Europe on January 13, 1908. Wilbur Wright had already made a similar circuit – with banked turns – on September 20, 1904.



October 30, 1908, after further modifications, including the addition of four large ailerons to his wings, Farman made the first cross-country flight (between two points, rather than circuits around a field), covering the 17 miles (27km) between Bouys and Reims in 20 minutes.

Success at last

In the winter of 1907–08, pushed into action by the increasingly successful flights of other experimenters, the Wright brothers finally agreed to deals to market their machines. In the United States the agreement was with the Army Signal Corps, and in France with a business syndicate. Each would buy Wright machines if they successfully fulfilled stringent performance criteria in public trials. While Orville stayed behind to prepare for the US military trials, Wilbur set off for France, having shipped an unassembled Flyer

“It is Farman who is first, incontestibly, to win the mastery of the air by airplane”

ERNEST ARCHDEACON
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ahead of him. However, it turned out that the machine had been severely damaged in customs, and Wilbur had to spend weeks making repairs. Had the aircraft not flown on August 8, 1908,

Wilbur would have faced utter public humiliation. Instead, his triumphant demonstration at the Hunaudières racetrack brought instant celebrity (see pages 20–21). Over the following months he flew repeatedly, attracting huge crowds. Gradually he extended his time in the air, culminating with an extraordinary flight of 2 hours 20 minutes on the final day of the year. He also set a new altitude record of 360ft (110m), and carried over

ROYAL INTEREST

England's King Edward VII (right), with Orville and Wilbur Wright (wearing his trademark flat cap), watches a flight in France in March 1909. Wilbur wrote: “Princes & millionaires are as thick as fleas.”

60 passengers, demonstrating that flight had become both practical and safe.

Orville's experience in the military trials at Fort Myer, Virginia, was less reassuring. His flights were a resounding success until September 17, when his Flyer crashed with a military observer on board, killing the passenger and injuring Orville (see page 34). Despite this setback, the army had seen enough to confirm its interest. In France, hostility toward the Wrights largely disappeared, for Wilbur's perfect control over his machine surpassed anything Europe had previously seen. Taken as sufficient proof of the Wrights' claims to earlier flights, aviation journalist François Peyrey expressed the opinion of the overwhelming majority when he wrote: “The Wright brothers are the first men who have succeeded in imitating the birds. To deny it would be childish.” French aviators now rushed to incorporate the key Wright characteristic, control in roll, into their machines.

The Wrights were now among the most famous men in the world. In 1909 they were immensely busy, demonstrating flight to the rich and powerful, dealing with the business offers that flooded in from all directions, and training pilots – a necessary part of sales contracts since Wilbur and Orville were the only people who knew how to fly their machines. Early in the year Wilbur was joined in Europe by Orville and their sister Katherine.

When they returned to the United States in late spring, they were belatedly feted at home. Dayton celebrated its local heroes with fireworks and a parade; the president received

